historians most certainly exaggerated, and that has to be taken into account. But even if we discount 90 per cent of these stories, the sheer volume and consistency of these scores of histories extending over the best part of eight hundred years cannot just be wished away, even if they are politically awkward or are misused by those determined to present Islam in India as un-Indian. The painful fact is that some invaders did glory in devastating infidel places of worship and in enslaving infidels, and their historians followed suit. Here, for example, is Amir Khusrao expressing his satisfaction at the damage done to Madurai:

> The orthodox Sunni victors had now piously compelled all false houses of worship to bow their heads on the prayer carpet of the ground and had broken all stone idols like the stony hearts of the worshippers. How clean the breast of those who broke with the greatest severity those contaminated stones, which Satan had raised like a wall before himself.

Precisely that same tone of bigoted self-satisfaction would later characterise the Portuguese chroniclers' accounts of their masters' wars up and down the Malabar coast, always fought (so they tell us) to the glory of God and the eternal damnation of the heathen.

By Zia-ud-Din Barni's account there were further raids on Madurai and elsewhere in the South in which more damage is said to have been inflicted. But when the third raid was carried out in 1323 its commander, the future Sultan Muhammad bin Tughlaq, stayed on to become governor of the new Muslim province of Ma'bar, nominally under the authority of the Sultans of Delhi. From then on Islam was present in the South as the faith of a ruling power.

By that time Cholamandalam's centuries of glory were a thing of the past. But the name persisted – to be Europeanised into Coromandel.